

THE LET THEM THEORY COMPANION GUIDE

LEADING WITH LET THEM

Mel Robbins
and
David Gerbitz

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Introduction

Over the years, I've had the privilege of working with some of the world's most successful companies—Starbucks, JPMorgan Chase, Headspace, Audible, Ulta Beauty, and more. And no matter where I go, one question comes up again and again:

How do I motivate my team?

The research is clear: whether you're leading an executive team, the night shift at the warehouse, training one new employee, or trying to manage the Little League team, the answer is the same: it's all based on how you show up.

Having a good boss is what creates good teams. That's where the Let Them Theory comes in.

You might be thinking, *You can't just let your team do whatever they want—they need to be managed.* True. But there's a big difference between guiding your team and controlling every move they make. When you micromanage, you risk stifling creativity, damaging relationships, and creating toxic work environments. In other words, a controlling boss is a bad boss.

The Let Them Theory is your key to finding the right balance. It's about empowering your team while providing the structure they need to succeed. It's about letting go of control without abandoning responsibility. And it starts with you.

And to make this guide the best it can be, I brought in someone with world-class operations and leadership experience inside some of the world's most respected publicly traded companies to help me write this chapter.

It's my honor to introduce you to David Gerbitz.

David is the former Chief Operating Officer of SiriusXM/Pandora Media and has been in other senior leadership roles at Amazon, Microsoft, Yahoo, and Qurate Retail Group.

He is now an executive coach and advisor, developing leaders and teams in hyper-dynamic industries across all stages of business. His client roster includes some of the best-known companies, including DoorDash, Microsoft, Walmart, Paradigm, Google, DuoLingo, SoundCloud, Twitch, and more.

And, he's also MY coach! I've worked with him for the past year. I believe that every leader, no matter how experienced, can benefit from having a coach—and I am no exception.

David is extraordinary at what he does, not just because of his deep operational and executive leadership experience but because of his understanding of what leadership truly is.

His wisdom has been transformative for me and my team. He's helped me amplify my strengths and lead from the incredibly high standards I hold for myself and my business. He's guided me to recognize and address my own “bad boss” behaviors—the ones we all have but sometimes struggle to see. His coaching has allowed me to lead with more clarity, intention, and impact.

That's why I've asked David to co-author this guide. We've put these concepts together for you because we share a passion and a belief that better leaders create a better world. And when you choose to lead with *Let Them*, you're not just building a stronger team—you're becoming a better version of yourself.

A handwritten signature in black ink, consisting of a horizontal line followed by the word "Mel" in a cursive script.

Part 1: Lead Yourself, First

The heart of being a good boss lies within—it's an inside job. Your title or position might give you authority, but true leadership comes from you: your mindset, your actions, and your ability to influence, not control. It's about how well you lead yourself because the energy you bring sets the tone for your entire team.

Every decision you make, every word you say, every reaction you have flows from one place: your inner world. Your beliefs and your lived experiences shape the way you interpret what's happening around you. This lens and your perspective color everything. It can help you lead with empathy and confidence, or it can trip you up, making you reactive, defensive, or ineffective.

Here's the kicker: most of us aren't even aware of that lens. We charge into the day, overwhelmed by stress, pressure, and the fear of getting it wrong. When that happens, our instinct is to control everything and protect ourselves. We move from leading to reacting. And from that stance, we are certain to create a chaotic environment for those we lead.

Let Self-Awareness Be Your Superpower

The foundation of great leadership is self-awareness and what you do with it. It's the ability to pause, reflect, and understand:

- *Why am I reacting this way?*
- *What belief or emotion is driving me right now?*
- *Is this response helping me lead, or is it holding me back?*

Self-awareness is about recognizing your talents and your strengths. But it is also about understanding your triggers, your fears, and your inner critic before they derail you. It's about getting curious about your behaviors, your assumptions, and your emotions. And here's the good news: self-awareness isn't something you're born with—it's something you build.

The more you understand yourself, the better you can manage your impulses and emotions in the moment. You'll lead with intention instead of reactivity. You'll shift from fear to clarity. And when you show up purposeful, calm, and grounded, your team can follow suit.

Leadership Amplifies Everything About You

In our own growth as leaders, we often return to this advice: *Leaders bring the weather*. It's simple but profound. Your mood, your energy, and your attitude set the tone for your team. If you show up stressed, anxious, or frenetic, guess what? That's the weather your team will work in. The wake of your behaviors directly impacts how your people will think, innovate, perform, or connect with others. When you frequently bring bad weather, you erode trust with your team and you will likely create a toxic work environment. And that, my friends, is horrible for business. But if you show up optimistic and focused, you create an environment where your people can succeed.

Today's leaders can be under extraordinary pressure. Technical innovation, market forces, the speed of disruption, talent dynamics, and societal complexities converge at work. We see leaders operating under an avalanche of stress. It becomes difficult to regulate themselves and show up as the leader they want to be. They end up in a state of negativity and wrestling with challenging emotions. In many cases, their long-held beliefs or assumptions and their go-to behaviors are not as effective. They struggle to perform, and they struggle to motivate their teams to perform. This is where coaches help leaders become more self-aware and effectively navigate this challenging weather.

The truth is leadership amplifies who you are and what you are experiencing in your life. This is why leading *yourself* is fundamental to leading others. If you're not managing your own emotions, mindset, and reactions, you can't expect your team to manage theirs. They look to you to set the tone. When you lead from your more challenged or negative behavior (for example, stress, anger, or insecurity), your own perspective is clouded, and your ability to influence is compromised.

It's important to do the hard work of looking inward. It's not easy to manage this. We know. In our own careers, we have brought thunderstorms on plenty of occasions. Leadership has a way of holding up a mirror to all the parts of yourself you'd rather not face. It confronts you with your fears and your blind spots. But the more courage you have to look at yourself honestly, the better you'll lead. The more intentional you are about the energy you bring, the better your team can perform.

When you lead yourself first, you:

- Understand how you impact others.
- Offer clarity instead of chaos.
- Build trust by modeling calm and confidence.
- Inspire your team to rise to your example.

Doing this work doesn't make you perfect—it means you're intentional. It means you show up every day committed to growing and being the kind of leader your team can trust.

So ask yourself: *What weather am I bringing today? And how is this impacting my ability to lead others? What choices am I making that help people thrive?*

Let Them vs. Control

In our years coaching executives or being coached ourselves, we have watched leaders waste valuable energy in destructive patterns of trying to control other people. This is especially true when under stress. If there is one area to examine it is the instinct to manage success by trying to control others.

Many leaders stumble because the instinct to control feels safer. You think, *If I don't step in, it won't get done right*. Or worse: *If we fail, it's on me*. That fear of failure and uncertainty starts to rage within you and tempts you to micromanage, approve every move, and dictate every solution. And this makes sense. When you didn't manage people, you just did it yourself and controlled your outcomes. You relied exclusively on you. But the game changes when you get work done through others. The skills that made you successful on your own are not the full set of skills that make you a good leader.

In leading other people, control doesn't create success. It kills it.

- **Micromanagement suffocates growth.** You rob your team of opportunities to think for themselves, take risks, and stretch beyond their comfort zones. Over time, you erode creativity, trust, and motivation.
- **Control breeds frustration and disengagement.** People don't like to feel watched, doubted, or underestimated. When they sense you don't trust them, they'll stop trying to earn it.
- **Control is exhausting.** Dictating every detail is unsustainable. It drains your time and energy while disempowering the people you're supposed to lead.

The *Let Them Theory* is the cornerstone of good leadership because it is not about control. It is also not about leaning back or giving up responsibility. It's about stepping fully into your role as a guide, coach, and enabler of success. It's about shifting from control to influence, from micromanagement to empowerment.

You are still the leader. You're still responsible for outcomes. But when you choose to *Let Them*, you stop trying to own it all and start creating the conditions where your team can

rise on their own terms. You're letting them think, decide, and perform with confidence. You're letting them take ownership.

When you lead with *Let Them*, you inspire accountability. You empower your team to bring their very best forward.

What leading with *Let Them* looks like:

1. ***Let Them own their work.*** Ownership is everything. When people are trusted to solve problems, make decisions, and bring their ideas to life, they take pride in the results. When you *Let Them*, their work becomes their own and not just your checklist
2. ***Let Them be themselves.*** The best teams are made up of people who show up as their authentic selves. They bring their unique strengths and perspectives. Leadership isn't about molding people into a singular version of success. It's about celebrating individuality and creating space for all voices to achieve greatness.
3. ***Let Them follow your clear direction.*** Empowerment doesn't mean stepping back completely or letting teams lack direction. Great leaders provide clarity of purpose, roles, goals, decisions, and expectations. When your team knows where they're going and why it matters, you create the guardrails they need to succeed.

Leading with *Let Them* is a mindset shift. It's about focusing on outcomes. It's about trusting your team to rise to the challenge and about being there to support them rather than suffocate them. Your job isn't to have all the answers. Your job is to create an environment where your team can find solutions.

When you lead with *Let Them*, everything changes. You break controlling patterns and unleash a sustainable, motivating, and high-performance energy.

- **Your team feels trusted.** When people know you believe in them, they show up with more confidence and care.
- **Your team innovates.** When failure isn't punished but seen as part of growth, people take risks, share ideas, and push boundaries.
- **Your team steps up.** Ownership drives accountability. When your team feels responsible for outcomes, they'll work harder to deliver.

The best leaders don't force results—they *inspire* them. They earn trust by being steady and by empowering their people. They know that letting their team own their work isn't a weakness—it's a strength. When you *Let Them*, you give your team the freedom and support they need, and you build a team that's more capable than you imagined.

So the next time you feel the urge to control, stop. Take a breath. Ask yourself: *Am I creating space for my team to grow, or am I standing in their way?*

5 Ways to *Let Me* Lead

Leadership is often misunderstood as the ability to direct or dictate—but true leadership is about **influence**. Influence is relational. It's about building connection, trust, and understanding. Influence inspires people to follow you not because they have to, but because they want to. People follow leaders who show them the way and who connect with them as human beings. Influence is how you move from simply managing work to truly leading people.

Control might get the job done and deliver short-term results, but it doesn't create followership, and it isn't a sustainable way to lead. It's transactional—do this, get that. Influence, however, is transformational. It inspires action, commitment, and long-term loyalty because it's rooted in the behaviors of trust and respect.

That's where *Let Me* comes in.

Let Me is about choosing influence over control, behaviors that inspire people to step up, take ownership, and bring their best to the table.

Let Me is about recognizing that the greatest influence you have as a leader isn't just in what you say or do—it's in who you are.

Let Me is a daily practice of leading yourself first and then igniting what is within you (your mindset, behaviors, and emotions) to inspire greatness in others.

Let Me is the act of self-reflection: *How am I showing up today? What energy am I bringing to my team? What choices can I make to lead with intention and purpose?*

There are many strategies to help you do this; for example, through empathy or with effective communication. However, we believe these five behaviors are critical in amplifying your ability to influence others.

#1. *Let Me* – Focus on What I Can Control

Great leaders don't force compliance—they inspire action through clarity and trust. It's natural to feel the pressure to control everything, especially when the stakes are high. But trying to relentlessly control outcomes, processes, or other people only drains your energy and stifles your team. Too much command and control only creates more dependence on it. It is important to shift your focus to what you can really control—your mindset, your emotions, and your behavior. You can then use your energy to set and clarify direction and enable your team.

Let Them doesn't mean letting chaos reign—it means anchoring yourself in what truly matters and modeling that for others. You can't control everything, but you can control the leader you choose to be.

HOW TO FOCUS ON WHAT YOU CAN CONTROL:

- 1. Recognize your triggers.** Know what gets under your skin. When you feel defensive, anxious, or frustrated, ask yourself: *“What’s really going on here? Is this about them, or is it about me?”* Understanding your emotional triggers helps you respond thoughtfully, not react impulsively.
- 2. Test your beliefs.** Just because you think something doesn't mean it's true. Ask yourself: *“Am I jumping to conclusions? Is there another way to view this?”* This small act of reframing shifts you from assumption to opportunity.
- 3. Pause before you respond.** Reacting in the heat of the moment rarely helps. Take a breath. Ask: *“Am I leading from fear, or am I leading from clarity?”* When you respond with intention, you model calm and focus for your team.
- 4. Lead by example.** Remember that your team mirrors your behavior. Negativity can create a lasting impression that acts like a contagion to your team. If you want them to handle challenges with grace, show them how it's done. Demonstrate the behaviors and the performance you want to see.

5. **Create space.** Leaders struggle to create a sense of agency for themselves. It is necessary to create time and capacity in the day to think or problem solve, to regulate, and to be intentional about how to lead others. We encourage leaders to find what works for them such as a consistent morning routine or dedicated work blocks or limiting back to back meetings.

#2. Let Me – Reframe Mistakes as Growth Opportunities

Mistakes offer opportunities for growth. This is at the heart of psychologist and author Carol Dweck’s **growth mindset**. This is the belief that our abilities, intelligence, and success are developed through learning, effort, and persistence. If you don’t embrace this mindset as a leader, your team won’t either.

Certainly, not all mistakes are created equal and it is important to know which ones might be catastrophic to your business. But too many leaders treat most mistakes as setbacks. They fixate on failures, assign blame and fail to open a channel for learning with their teams. Over time, their people start to avoid risks. Nothing innovative or extraordinary comes from playing it safe. When you reframe mistakes as opportunities to grow, you inspire people to take chances, stretch their abilities, and improve.

And guess what? This applies to you, too. Leaders are evolving as well, mistakes and all.

Failures aren’t always setbacks. They provide valuable learning opportunities. When you embrace this mindset, you’re not letting your team fail—you’re letting them evolve. And when you model it yourself, you give them permission to grow with you.

HOW TO REFRAME MISTAKES AS GROWTH OPPORTUNITIES:

1. **Normalize mistakes.** When something goes wrong, don’t default to blame. Instead, ask: *“What can we learn from this? What will we do differently next time?”* Mistakes can be a powerful stepping stone to progress.

2. **Celebrate effort, not just outcomes.** Acknowledge the courage it takes to try something new, even if it doesn't work. For example: *"I love that you pushed yourself to tackle this challenge. What did you take away from it?"*
3. **Share your own growth.** Your team needs to see you model your own development. Share when you have also failed, what you learned, and how you improved. This showcases your humility and helps build trust.
4. **Encourage calculated risk-taking.** Give your team permission to experiment. Say: *"Let's try it. If it doesn't work, we'll learn and adjust."* Fear of failure kills creativity; trust fuels it.

#3. Let Me – Manage by Outcomes

Your team doesn't need you to micromanage every detail. They need you to set the vision and trust them. Leadership isn't about dictating every step. Your job is to be clear about what needs to happen and then empower your team to figure out how to get there.

When you focus on outcomes instead of control, you shift the ownership and the accountability to them.

Micromanaging might feel safer, but it's a trap. It stifles creativity, drains motivation, and robs your team of ownership. Instead, focus on outcomes. Avoid trying to define and direct every solution. You may not be as close to the work or have the full context of the issues, and your directives could be ineffective. Trust your team to rise to the challenge, and let yourself be surprised by what they can achieve.

HOW TO MANAGE BY OUTCOMES:

1. **Be clear on the "what" and the "why."** Define the outcome you wish to achieve. Help root cause the problem they need to solve, and explain why it matters. When people understand the purpose behind their work, they're more motivated to succeed.

2. **Trust the process (even when it's not yours).** Set expectations, and then step back. Your way isn't the only way. Offer clear direction and offer guidance, but give your team some freedom to solve problems their way. Resist the urge to jump in unless needed.
3. **Check-in, don't take over.** Regular check-ins allow you to offer support and guidance without micromanaging. Ask: *"What progress are we making, and why? What challenges can I help with?"* *"On a scale of 1-10, how do you think the project is going?"*
4. **Evaluate results, not methods.** If the work meets the standard, does it matter how they got there? Celebrate the outcome, not the exact process they used to achieve it.

#4. Let Me – Be Personable and Present

People don't follow titles, they follow leaders they admire and connect with. Leadership isn't just about results; it's about relationships. When you show up as someone who listens, cares, and sees your people, you build the trust that fuels performance.

Being personable and present doesn't mean being everyone's best friend. It invites you to be human and show up as your authentic self. It is also about being attentive. It is increasingly difficult to limit distractions and to give your team the attention they need, but doing so is incredibly important. Show the team that they matter—not just as workers, but as people. Give people your time and your attention and encourage your team to do the same for one another.

Being personable and present isn't a "nice-to-have"—it's *essential*. Your team doesn't just want to work for you—they want to work with you. When you're present and connected, you create loyalty and the kind of culture where people feel seen, valued, and inspired.

HOW TO BE PERSONABLE AND PRESENT:

1. **Be fully present.** When you're with your people, be with your people. Put away your phone, shut your laptop, and focus on the moment. Slow down. *Listen actively*—not just to respond, but to understand. Distraction kills trust; presence builds it.
2. **Ask meaningful questions.** Lean into curiosity. Go beyond “How’s it going?” and ask: “*How can I support you? What’s challenging you right now? What are you most proud of?*” These questions show care, but they also invite deeper connections and insight.
3. **Show your humanity.** Leadership isn’t about perfection—it’s about authenticity. Share about your own wins, challenges, and learnings. Show yourself. Your realness makes you approachable and relatable.
4. **Find your calm.** How sustainable is anxiety as a motivator? Our work environment and our society is no stranger to frenetic energy. While some of this shows up as excitement or assertiveness, we believe staying present with a sense of calm is an increasingly important attribute for leaders. Let the work be intense, but let your leadership take a breath.

#5. **Let Me – Be Consistent**

Consistency is an incredibly important behavior in leadership. It’s not flashy, but it is a steady and stable way to influence others. Your team doesn’t just want to know what to expect from you—they need to know they can expect it.

When leaders are inconsistent—whether it’s in their communication, feedback, decision-making, or behavior—it creates uncertainty. Uncertainty is the enemy of progress. It breeds stress, frustration, and disengagement.

But when you’re consistent? Everything changes. You become the leader people can depend on. Your team feels grounded. They don’t have to waste mental energy navigat-

ing uncertainty or guessing your expectations. Instead, they can focus on doing their best work.

HOW TO BE A CONSISTENT LEADER:

- 1. Be clear and steady in your communication.** Whether you're sharing goals, providing feedback, or setting expectations, be consistent in what you say and how you say it. Mixed messages create confusion and chip away at trust.
- 2. Follow through on your commitments.** When you say you'll do something, do it. Your actions should match your words every time. Nothing erodes trust faster than broken promises or unfulfilled commitments.
- 3. Establish predictable rhythms.** Regular one-on-ones, team meetings, consistent communication, and clear decision-making processes provide structure. As they saying goes "*with structure comes freedom*". These rhythms do just that. They help secure your leadership as more dependable and keep your team confident in what to expect.
- 4. Model consistent behavior.** Your team mirrors what they see. If your mood, priorities, or expectations shift unpredictably, your team will respond with hesitation and doubt. Show up steady, intentional, and aligned with your values.

Coaching leaders is deeply rewarding because we witness their journey as they unlock new awareness and potential. For many, leadership development is their best or perhaps only opportunity to shift into the leader they want to be—not only in work but in life.

We get a front-row seat to the transformation and the impact. When leaders *Let Me*, they focus on improving themselves—the only thing they can really control. They use that awareness to develop new skills and develop the power of influence. They see clearly their role in service to their teams and that there is a better way to lead, and a better way to *Let Them* thrive.

Part 2: ***Let Them Thrive***

If you're going to *Let Them*, you also need to **enable them**. Your leadership isn't just about influencing and relinquishing control—it's about creating the conditions and the capacity for your people to achieve greatness. Great teams are built intentionally, where people feel safe to be their authentic selves, where they are valued, and where they are empowered to do their best work.

And guess what? You create that environment.

You have the power to remove the barriers that slow your team down, to clear the path for progress, and to build a culture that inspires ownership and accountability. When you *Let Them* achieve, you're not abandoning responsibility—you're fulfilling it in the most meaningful way.

Every time you remove a barrier—whether it's confusion, lack of process, or a fear of failure—you open the door for someone to step into their full potential. Every time you show your team that their contributions matter, you're building trust and momentum.

Your team doesn't show up to work as robots—they show up as people. They bring with them their hopes, their ambitions, and yes, the weight of stress, uncertainty, and challenges. Today's workplace is faster, more demanding, and more ambiguous than ever before. Teams are managing cognitive overload, work velocity, constant change, uncertainty, and distributed workplaces. They are experiencing a world that often feels increasingly divided and overwhelming. Their reality doesn't stay outside the office—*it walks in with them*.

That's why the environment you create at work is everything. When your team feels enabled and empowered, they'll bring their full energy and best ideas to the table. They'll trust you, they'll trust each other, and they'll trust themselves to step up, take risks, and deliver.

8 Ways to Build a High-Performance Environment

Creating an environment that enables your people takes deliberate effort and intentional leadership. Whether you're leading a small team or an entire organization, these eight strategies will help you create a foundation for sustained excellence and growth.

1. Inspire a Courageous Culture

In 2012, Google launched **Project Aristotle**, a groundbreaking internal study to uncover what makes teams effective. Their conclusion? The #1 factor wasn't talent, resources, or strategy—it was **psychological safety**. This concept, developed by Harvard professor Amy Edmondson, is the belief that you can take risks, share ideas, and make mistakes without fear of judgment, punishment, or ridicule.

Courageous cultures aren't "soft" cultures. They are *high-performing* ones. Why? Because when people feel safe enough to speak up, ask hard questions, admit mistakes, and share bold ideas, trust deepens, collaboration thrives, and innovation takes off. Vulnerability is the foundation of trust, and trust is what allows courage to flourish. Without it, your team will hesitate, hold back, and play it safe. And nothing extraordinary comes from playing it safe.

You would be shocked at how common it is for teams to feel afraid of being honest with their boss. When this safety is absent, teams become silent. They keep their ideas to themselves, avoid challenging the status quo, and tiptoe around problems because they fear judgment. They stop taking risks. This quickly creates toxicity where mistakes get hidden, creativity is stifled, political jockeying reigns, and progress stalls. Leaders are left standing alone, reinforcing their own half-truths, which harms the business and their credibility.

On the flip side, in a courageous culture, mistakes become opportunities to learn. Hard conversations lead to better solutions. New ideas are welcomed.

Imagine a team where people feel brave enough to bring their ideas forward, even if they're not fully baked. Imagine a team where someone can say, *"I messed up,"* and the first response is, *"Thank you for telling me. What did we learn?"* Imagine a team where people challenge each other—not to tear each other down, but to build each other up. That's a courageous culture.

As a leader, you set the tone. Your team is watching you. If you want a culture where people show up courageously, you need to show up courageously first. Be the leader who says, *"I don't have all the answers,"* who asks hard questions, and who celebrates effort over perfection.

Because courage is contagious. When you *Let Them* feel safe, seen, and valued, you inspire greatness.

See Do's & Don'ts on the next page.

DO



Let Them be themselves. Encourage authenticity and celebrate unique strengths and differences.



Model vulnerability. Share your own challenges and growth opportunities to normalize openness and champion development.



Respond with more curiosity. Ask, "What did we learn?" when mistakes happen.



Encourage post-mortems. Create the space for teams to review work outcomes and projects and *Let Them* learn from failure. Create best practices.

DON'T



Expect conformity, discourage individuality, or force people to fit a mold.



Avoid showing weakness or pretend to have all the answers.



Criticize or assign blame in a way that creates fear around failure or shuts down new ideas.



Miss the opportunity to share learning and improve from failures.

2. Create Clarity

Ambiguity kills progress. It's the silent saboteur that slows teams down and leaves people spinning in circles. If your team isn't clear on their roles, goals, or the direction you're heading, they're not moving forward—they're hesitating, second-guessing, and losing confidence. Unfortunately, this happens a lot. We find lack of clarity to be a root cause of most work conflicts.

Without clear expectations, people feel unmoored. They're forced to guess, they duplicate efforts, or worse, they stop trying altogether because they're afraid of getting it wrong. This slows progress and erodes trust. It creates chaos. Teams that lack clarity experience frustration, resentment, infighting, and burnout because people spend more energy figuring out what to do than actually doing it.

Clarity is particularly important when managing poor performance (as is delivering feedback, which we address). While you can still manage outcomes, you may need to be more clear on the process. While you can still value growth, you may need to be more clear about defining mistakes and their implications. You may need to be even more clear about roles, responsibilities, timelines, and directives.

When you're clear about what success looks like, you give your people the freedom to find their own way. Because when you *Let Them* see the path forward, they don't just follow it—they run.

See Do's & Don'ts on the next page.

DO



Define roles and responsibilities. Ensure everyone knows what they own, the role they play, and what they are accountable for. If working in teams, ensure everyone has role clarity in how to work together.



Set clear goals. Explain what success looks like and why it matters. Be specific about the outcomes you want to achieve.



Reinforce priorities. Communicate regularly to keep your team aligned on what matters most. If priorities have to shift, communicate this clearly.



Clarify decisions. Lack of decisioning is a key barrier for teams. Ensure everyone is clear about who makes decisions, what decisions are needed, and by when.

DON'T



Leave roles or goals ambiguous, making your team guess what's expected of them.



Assume people understand your direction without explanation or alignment.



Overload your team with changing or conflicting priorities.



Let your teams waste time or endure needless conflict due to a lack of decision-making.

3. Celebrate Your People

If there's one thing your people want, it's to feel seen, valued and appreciated. Recognition isn't just a pat on the back or a quick “*good job*”—it's a fundamental human need. When people feel recognized for their efforts, they don't just perform better—they flourish. They feel motivated to keep going, to dig deeper, and to show up as their best selves.

This should be an easy one, but it's not something leaders pull forward in their day. Recognition is one of the easiest tools for a leader, yet it's also underutilized. It doesn't cost a dime to say “*thank you*” or “*I see how hard you worked on this,*” and yet, when it's absent, morale drops, engagement falters, and people start to question whether what they're doing even matters.

Celebrating your people also means creating community. This is especially important in remote and hybrid work environments. Creating social connection is a necessary act of celebration that fosters collaboration and unity.

You can't build a high-performing team without making people feel valued. Recognition matters. When you let your team know they're appreciated, you're not just creating a culture of gratitude—you're building a team that feels connected and committed. *Let Them* know you see their unique talents—and they'll be inspired to do even more.

See Do's & Don'ts on the next page.

DO



Celebrate wins. Recognize accomplishments and effort. Showcase your talent and highlight best practices and good work.



Be specific with recognition. Take the opportunity to show your people that they are valued by being specific with what you recognize. This feedback reinforces what you deem excellent.



Say thank you often. Simple acknowledgments build trust and goodwill.



Create social connection and community: Foster collaboration and connection often, especially in remote environments.

DON'T



Ignore them, downplay their successes, or take their value for granted.



Offer vague praise like, "Good job," without acknowledging specifics.



Assume people know they're appreciated without verbalizing it.



Miss the opportunity to bring teams together for social connection.

4. Create Meaning at Work

A good leader doesn't just assign tasks—they inspire meaning. Remind your team the difference they're making, and watch them rise to meet it. People don't just want a paycheck; they want purpose. They want to know that what they're doing matters and that their contributions make a difference. When people understand the meaning of their work, everything shifts.

There is dignity in our work and every role has a purpose. It's the leader's job to help connect the dots. You have the power to validate the way people see their work.

Meaning builds pride, personal fulfillment, and it ignites ownership. A mechanic isn't just fixing cars; they're helping families get where they need to go safely. A coder isn't just writing lines of software; they're solving problems that make people's lives easier. A teacher isn't just sharing information; they're changing the trajectory of someone's future.

When you inspire meaning, teams no longer feel like they're just working—they're contributing. They're creating impact.

See Do's & Don'ts on the next page.

DO



Connect them to the mission. Show how their work creates value and contributes to the company's goals and values.



Share stories of impact. Communicate how their work benefits others.



Inspire with vision. Remind people of the "why" behind their work. Help them create a powerful narrative for themselves and the work they do.



Understand them. Be curious about what your people value and what gives them meaning in work so that you can support their career.

DON'T



Focus solely on tasks without connecting them to the bigger picture.



Ignore the human impact of the team's efforts.



Assume they'll stay motivated without understanding the importance of their contribution.



Assume that what motivates you is what motivates them.

5. Balance Expectations with Kindness

High-performing teams don't happen by accident. They're built on ambitious goals and the belief that people are capable of great things. But remember, sustainable performance doesn't come from relentless pressure or fear—it comes from feeling supported. We find leaders really struggle here. They often seek coaching on how to drive performance while also being supportive (and kind). They are challenged by an internal programming that can't see how these behaviors work beautifully together.

Balancing high expectations with kindness doesn't mean you're "soft." It means you're smart. Research shows that people perform at their best when they feel respected and supported. A boss who drives performance and shows genuine care earns the loyalty and motivation of their team. When people know you see them—not just as employees, but as people with important lives—they'll go above and beyond. The best leaders partner with their teams to achieve ambitious goals.

Striking this balance between driving results and showing genuine care is one of the most important jobs of a boss. Leaders need to drive performance beyond short-term wins. They need to create the conditions to succeed and inspire people to bring their best every day. Go ahead and push high expectations, but *Let Them* achieve by knowing you're there to support them, not add to their stress.

See Do's & Don'ts on the next page.

DO



Set high standards: Hold people accountable. Create a feeling of empowerment and ownership. Push for high-quality performance and outcomes. Keep the bar high.



Stay connected: Check in on their workload and their wellbeing, regularly. Connect on a personal level.



Enable their success: Offer support and resources to meet challenges.

DON'T



Sacrifice quality or overlook missed deliverables.



Assume people will let you know if they're struggling.



Add stress without providing solutions or support.

6. Deliver and Seek Feedback

Providing consistent feedback is a powerful tool in a leader's toolkit. It enables performance, strengthens relationships, and builds trust. And yet, leaders have a hard time with this. They either avoid feedback entirely or they focus so heavily on criticism that they unintentionally chip away at their team's confidence.

Feedback isn't just about fixing mistakes. Feedback is about growth. It's about helping people see their potential, reinforcing what's working, and giving them the direction they need to improve. It's a good practice for leaders to simply let their teams know that they can expect regular feedback as part of the way they work.

Balancing the feedback is usually the best bet. You can provide a clear, honest view of performance while also recognizing strengths and effort. This makes it actionable and trustworthy. You show your team that you see their accomplishments, and that you're also willing to share the truth about their opportunities.

An important part of feedback is also about asking for it, for yourself. Leadership training often emphasizes how to give feedback, but less time is spent on the equally powerful practice of seeking it. When you invite feedback, you send a message that we are a team that values it. You signal that your leadership is about being curious, staying open, and remaining committed to growth.

The best leaders aren't the ones who pretend to have it all figured out—they're the ones who keep asking, *"How can I do this better?"* Let Them see your leadership as a practice of transparency and growth.

See Do's & Don'ts on the next page.

DO



Be specific. Feedback should be situational, timely, and clear. It should focus on the behaviors you see and the impact of those behaviors on performance.



Lead with curiosity. When offering constructive feedback, ask questions vs. jumping to conclusions: *"What was your goal with this? What could we do differently next time?"* Create a dialogue that keeps people engaged instead of defensive.



Balance positive and constructive feedback. Negativity bias is a real thing. Research says to aim for at least a 5:1 ratio of positive to negative feedback.



Ask for feedback. Show that you're open to improvement, and do so frequently. Say, *"What's one thing I can do better to support you?"* or *"How could I have handled that differently?"* Validate it by acting on it.

DON'T



Offer vague or overly general feedback.



Assume or tell vs. coach and listen.



Focus solely on criticism without acknowledging strengths.



Avoid seeking feedback out of fear of hearing something critical.

7. Provide Tools, Development, and Resources

Even the most talented team will hit a wall if they don't have what they need to succeed.

Your job as a leader is to anticipate what your people need and make sure they have it. This doesn't just mean providing technology or training—it means actively removing the barriers that get in their way. Great leaders don't just tell their team to “figure it out”—they ask, “*What do you need, and how can I help clear the way?*”

Providing tools, development, and resources isn't just a practical step. You're signaling to your team: “*I believe in you.*” “*I want you to succeed.*” “*I'm willing to invest in you.*” People want to work for leaders who actively support their success. And when they feel that investment, they're more likely to show up and perform.

Providing what your team needs is one of the clearest ways to *Let Them*.

Let Them do their best work.

Let Them develop.

Let Them see that you're in their corner every step of the way.

See Do's & Don'ts on the next page.

DO



Invest in business enablers: Ensure they have the technology, time, resources, and streamlined processes to do their jobs effectively.



Focus on Development: Offer skill development, mentorship, coaching, on-the-job stretch assignments, and/or training opportunities.



Remove Barriers (quickly): Pay attention to what's getting in the way – bureaucratic bottlenecks, lack of clarity, or unclear processes. Resolve these immediately.

DON'T



Allow outdated tools or processes to slow progress.



Assume people will figure it out without proper resources.



Let obstacles persist that hinder progress.

8. Manage Good Conflict

Conflict has a bad reputation. Not all conflict is harmful. In fact, *good conflict*—the kind that’s productive, honest, and rooted in mutual respect—is essential for innovation and growth. The problem isn’t conflict itself; it’s when leaders avoid it or allow it to spiral into something toxic.

Conflict can be the enemy of progress, or it can be the catalyst for it. We usually see leaders avoid it. They fail to name conflict, which means they can’t guide through it and they can’t mine it for opportunity. Conflict at senior levels has a particularly destructive impact on teams because it forces everyone to swirl in the wake of unresolved issues at the top. Leaders who fear conflict more than landing tough decisions or resolving differences not only hurt business, they lead their teams down a needlessly challenging path.

When you don’t manage conflict, tension simmers below the surface, trust erodes, and small problems snowball into bigger ones. Teams start to avoid hard conversations, ideas go unexplored, and resentment quietly builds. In these environments, people don’t speak up because they’re afraid. They fear judgment, blame, or unnecessary drama. Avoiding conflict doesn’t keep the peace, but it does create an illusion of it. Over time, unspoken issues fester, collaboration suffers, and your team stops challenging the status quo. The opportunity at the core of the conflict is lost.

When you learn to manage *good conflict* you create a culture where honest conversations feel safe and necessary. You model that hard truths can be handled with calm and intention. You unlock new possibilities where people can challenge ideas and push each other to be better. Healthy conflict brings forward fresh perspectives, drives clarity, and creates deeper trust because it proves that honesty and candor are valued over silence and avoidance.

See Do’s & Don’ts on the next page.

DO



Name the conflict. Conflict can involve relationships, but it can also be structural (example: lack of role clarity). Work to jointly define the conflict you are experiencing so that you can root cause the solution.



Focus on solutions, not blame. Keep the conversation centered on solving problems and moving forward.



Encourage open dialogue. Create a space where people feel safe to share their thoughts, concerns, and ideas.



Model constructive conflict. Show your team how to have difficult conversations calmly and productively.



Follow through on resolution. Make sure conflicts lead to clear outcomes, action steps, or agreements.

DON'T



Misunderstand the conflict or the opportunity it presents.



Use conflict to assign blame and further escalate fractured relationships.



Clamp down on dissent and silence conflicting perspectives.



Avoid conflict or let it fester within the team.

Your Leadership Legacy

Leadership is *influence*, which means it requires you to take an exciting and powerful journey into self discovery. In our experience, it is one of the greatest teachers in adulthood. It challenges you to grow in ways you wouldn't think necessary or possible.

Leadership requires that you become intentional. You must show up not just to manage tasks, but to lead yourself, first. You must develop what it takes for you to effectively enable others and empower them to succeed.

While you cannot control others, you have the power to shape how your team feels about themselves and the work that they do. Your influence can help someone see their potential when they can't see it themselves. You can help turn doubt into confidence, hesitation into action, and effort into excellence. Imagine how that impacts their day. Now think about the next day... and the day after that. And who they might become because of your leadership. And who might others become because of theirs?

When you *Let Them*—you give your team the space to grow, and to fail, and to succeed. You're not just creating great results. You're creating an impact that reaches far beyond your time as their leader. This extends into their families, their careers, and their lives. It can inspire them to show up for others the way you showed up for them. You can be the kind of boss who makes people want to bring their best.

The legacy of a good leader isn't just measured by what you achieve—it's measured by what you inspire others to achieve. It's the belief you spark, the growth you nurture, and the potential you set free.

Because when you *Let Them*, you not only enable their success, you become part of it. You discover their greatness—and yours.



David Gerbitz is a recognized authority in operational excellence and leadership, having scaled hyper-dynamic tech, retail, and media companies. His insights now fuel his advising and executive coaching practice.

David was previously the Chief Operating Officer for Pandora Media / SiriusXM, where he helped shape the market for digital audio advertising. He was also the Chief People Officer of Qurate Retail Group, leading the Company's global talent strategy and operations. David has held senior leadership roles at Amazon, Yahoo!, and Microsoft.

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THE LET THEM THEORY COMPANION GUIDE

LEADING WITH LET THEM

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